

# Session 3: The Ancient Shape of the Scriptures

## Key Takeaways

- Jesus’ Bible was a three-part collection of scrolls called the TaNaK. TaNaK is a designation for the Hebrew Bible taken from the first letter of its three major sections. T stands for Torah, which is Hebrew for "instruction;" N is for Nevi'im, meaning "prophets;" and K is for Ketuvim, meaning "writings."
- The three-part macro design dates to somewhere in the 3rd-2nd century B.C.E. This order is preserved in modern Jewish tradition and is well-attested in Second Temple Jewish texts and the New Testament.

## The Macro-Shape of the TaNaK

**Luke 24:25-27 NIV**

<sup>25</sup> [Jesus] said to [the disciples], “How foolish you are, and how slow to believe all that the prophets have spoken! <sup>26</sup> Did not the Messiah have to suffer these things and then enter his glory?” <sup>27</sup> And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he explained to them what was said in all the Scriptures concerning himself.

The Hebrew and Greek Scriptures that Jesus and the apostles read consisted of a three-part collection called the TaNaKh (a.k.a. TaNaK) in later Jewish tradition.

The final composition of the TaNaK scrolls dates somewhere in the 3rd-2nd centuries B.C.E. This date is provided by the latest books added to the collection (Chronicles and Esther in the 4th-3rd century B.C.E.), and also by the probable date of the final editorial activity that adapted scrolls into the collection (the expanded editions of Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Daniel, etc.).

## TaNaK Compared with the Christian Old Testament

The organization and order of the TaNaK differs in a couple significant ways from the way the same content is arranged in the Old Testament of modern Christian Bibles.

| TaNaK                                                                                                                                       | Christian Old Testament |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|
| Torah (The Law)                                                                                                                             | Pentateuch              |
| TaNaK Compared with the Christian Old Testament. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019). |                         |

| TaNak                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | Christian Old Testament                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Nevi'im (The Prophets)</b><br><br>Former Prophets<br>Joshua, Judges, Samuel, Kings<br><br>Latter Prophets<br>Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel<br>Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah,<br>Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah,<br>Malachi | <b>History</b><br><br>Joshua, Judges, Ruth<br>1-2 Samuel, 1-2 Kings<br>1-2 Chronicles<br>Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther<br><br><b>Poetry</b><br><br>Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs |
| <b>Ketuvim (The Writings)</b><br><br>Psalms, Job, Proverbs<br>Ruth, Song of Songs, Ecclesiastes, Lamentations,<br>Esther [The <i>Megillot</i> ]<br>Daniel, Ezra-Nehemiah, Chronicles                                                                | <b>Prophets</b><br><br>Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations<br>Ezekiel, Daniel<br>Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah,<br>Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah,<br>Malachi             |
| <i>TaNak Compared with the Christian Old Testament.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                |

## Ancient Evidence for the Shape of the TaNaK

When Jesus alludes to the order of the Hebrew Bible, he assumes a three-part design, which agrees with other contemporary Jewish authors who allude to the ordered sections.

- Luke 24:44: “This is what I told you while I was still with you: Everything must be fulfilled that is written about me in the Torah of Moses, the Prophets and the Psalms.”
- Luke 11:50-51: “Therefore this generation will be held responsible for the blood of all the prophets that has been shed since the beginning of the world, from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah, who was killed between the altar and the sanctuary.”
- Abel was murdered by Cain in Genesis 4, and Zechariah son of Jehoiadah was murdered by Joash in 2 Chronicles 24, which corresponds to the TaNaK order.
- Prologue to the Wisdom of Ben Sirach: “Many great teachings have been given to us through the Law [= Torah], and the Prophets [= Nevi'im], and the others that follow them [= Ketuvim] ... So my grandfather Yeshua devoted himself especially to the reading of the Law and the Prophets and the other scrolls of our Ancestors.”
- Dead Sea Scrolls (4QMMT): “The scrolls of Moses, the words of the prophets, and of David.”

- Philo of Alexandria (*De Vita Contemplativa*, 25): “The laws and the oracles given by inspiration through the prophets and the Psalms, and the other scrolls whereby knowledge and piety are increased and completed.”

## **Reflection Question**

What are some of the main differences between the TaNaK arrangement and the Christian arrangement of the Old Testament/Hebrew Bible? Could a different arrangement change the meaning of a text in the Bible?